

Italy, the Netherlands, Belgium, and Luxembourg in 1952, the first step on the road toward European union.

1954 After a massive defeat at Dien Bien Phu at the hands of Vietnamese nationalists, France pulls out of southeast Asia and recognizes the independence of a divided Vietnam, Laos, and Cambodia. France hands over its remaining possessions in the subcontinent to India. War of Independence breaks out in Algeria against French rule.

1956 Morocco and Tunisia gain their independence.

1956 France and UK take part in an abortive war to reverse Egypt's nationalization of the Suez Canal.

1957 France signs the Treaty of Rome with its five ECSC partners to create the European Economic Community.

1958 Fifth Republic is formed after the Fourth Republic collapses as army defiance in Algeria threatens civil war. De Gaulle becomes president.

1960 All French colonies in Africa except two gain their independence. The Comoros Islands become independent in 1975, Djibouti in 1977.

1962 Algerian independence is won after bitter war with France comes to an end.

1966 France withdraws from NATO military command as it pursues an increasingly independent foreign policy.

1968 General strike and student demonstrations over wages and education policy lead to turmoil across France. The National Assembly is dissolved but the Gaullists win the general election.

1969 De Gaulle resigns after defeat in referendum on regional reform and is replaced as president by Georges Pompidou, who dies in office in 1974.

1970 Death of de Gaulle.

1974 Valéry Giscard d'Estaing is elected president in a center-right coalition.

1981 The Socialist Party (PS) candidate François Mitterrand is elected president.

1983–86 After pursuing protectionist socialist economic policies, the government begins to deregulate the economy.

1986 "Cohabitation" between socialist president and a new right-wing government led by Jacques Chirac.

1988 Mitterrand wins second term. A PS-led coalition returns to government.

1991 Edith Cresson becomes France's first woman prime minister.

1992 France signs Maastricht treaty on European Union.

1993 Center-right coalition wins election.

1995 Jacques Chirac, the right-wing candidate, is elected president, ending 14 years of socialist presidency.

1995–96 Series of nuclear tests in French Polynesia conducted despite international condemnation.

1996 Unpopular austerity measures introduced to prepare the economy for European monetary union.

1997 Center-right loses elections: a PS-led government takes office with Lionel Jospin as prime minister.

1998–99 Extensive privatization program is initiated.

2000 Thirty-five-hour week becomes law. Chirac embroiled in corruption scandal.

2001 Compulsory military service is abolished.

2002 Euro replaces the franc.

2002 Jacques Chirac is reelected president. The National Front leader Jean-Marie Le Pen's strong showing in first round of voting sends shockwaves throughout France and leads to mass protests. These elections are first with presidential and parliamentary elections fought on the same five-year timetable, ending difficulties of cohabitation.

2002 Widespread public-sector worker strikes over privatization program bring country to a standstill.

2003 France is heavily critical of the US–UK invasion of Iraq. An estimated 11,000 elderly people die in severe heatwave in August.

2004 Protests by France's sizeable Muslim community when French MPs vote to ban the headscarf in schools.

2005 Referendum rejects proposed EU constitution. Prime minister Jean-Pierre Raffarin resigns. Unrest among deprived immigrant youths sparks riots that spread throughout cities. State of emergency is declared.

2006 New youth employment laws spark mass demonstrations across France. The legislation is dropped when the protests continue. Tough new restrictions on immigration make it harder for unskilled migrants to settle in France.

2007 Nicolas Sarkozy wins presidential election for the right, defeating Ségolène Royale of the Socialists in the second round, as Jacques Chirac steps down from power.

2008 Société Générale loses 5 billion euros due to unauthorized trading by a single rogue trader.

2010 The French government's order to dismantle illegal Roma Gypsy camps is controversial in other EU countries, who claim this contravenes directives on freedom of movement. President Sarkozy's party suffers heavy losses in regional elections, losing in 20 out of 22 regions.

«110–13 From Republic to Empire
«188–91 Medieval Europe
«256–59 The Reformation
«262–63 The 30 Years War
«270–71 The Enlightenment
«278–79 Louis XIV
«296–97 The First Global Conflict
«300–01 The Storming of the Bastille
«302–03 Revolution in France
«304–05 Napoleon Bonaparte
«306–07 The Napoleonic Wars
«412–13 End of the Colonial Era



The casino lifestyle

Monaco's fortunes were transformed when Prince Charles III, after whom the main town of Monte Carlo is named, opened a casino (above) in 1878, attracting both big money and tourism.

Monaco



A tiny principality on the Mediterranean coast, used as a tax haven by Europe's super-rich.

1191 Ancient port of Monaco is ceded by Henry VI, Holy Roman Emperor, to Genoa.

1297 The Grimaldis, an ancient Genoese family, establish themselves as the principality's hereditary rulers.

1641 Becomes a French protectorate.

1793 During the French Revolution, Monaco is annexed.

1814 Under the Treaty of Paris the Grimaldis regain power.

1860 Independent under French protection.

1911 First constitution drafted.

1929 First Monaco Grand Prix.

1949 Rainier III accedes to the throne.

1962 End of absolute authority of the prince; women obtain the vote.

1963 Democratic legislative elections held for first time.

1982 Princess Grace, a former Hollywood film star and wife of Prince Rainier, dies following a car accident.

1993 Monaco joins UN, becoming the smallest member state.

2002 Constitution revised. A new succession law is passed, designed to keep the Grimaldi family on the throne if Crown Prince Albert has no heir.

2005 Prince Albert succeeds his father.

DECISIVE MOMENT

STUDENT PROTESTS, 2006

On March 18, 2006, some 700,000 protesters converged on Paris and clashed violently with riot police. The demonstrators were objecting to a controversial bill to deregulate the labor market by making it easier to fire people under 26. The bill was perceived as grossly unfair because it made young people's jobs insecure. A month after the protest President Chirac scrapped the bill. Giving in to the protesters was seen by many observers as a missed opportunity for France to implement badly needed economic reforms and to free its labor market from stifling regulation.

Revolutionary spirit
Young protesters storm the Place de la Nation in Paris and throw the government into turmoil.

